

The Known World

A Campaign Gazetteer

The world of **Orruvane** — the charted continent in the year **211 After the Sundering**

The Known World • 211 AS



The continent of The Known World, two centuries after the Sundering. Twenty realms; one healing wound at the heart.

Twenty realms; one healing wound at the heart.

This document is canon, not memory. Everything here is meant to be read, not recalled. The map lives as data in engine/data/known_world.py and engine/data/home_halvedd.py; the playable picture is generated from that data by render/worldmap.py. When something must be true — where a realm sits, who rules it, what a hex contains — the answer comes from the data and the tools, never from a guess. When the data is silent, the right move is to flag the gap and decide together, never to invent.

1. The World at a Glance

The Known World is a continent of **twenty realms** sharing one broken inheritance. Two centuries ago it was the heart of a single empire. Then the empire reached too far, and the world *broke* — an event remembered simply as **the Sundering**. What remains is a patchwork of successor kingdoms, free states, savage frontiers, and elder powers, none strong enough to rule the rest and all too proud to kneel.

This is a **balanced fantasy world** in the old tradition. The gods are real and answer their priests. The demihuman peoples — elves, dwarves, halflings, gnomes, and stranger kin — are woven through its history. Magic exists and matters, but since the Sundering it is **feared as much as prized**: in the wrong places it runs wild, and the catastrophe that broke the world was, at bottom, a working of magic that should never have been attempted.

The tone shifts as you travel. The civilized heartland is **Tolkienesque** — fading glory, deep history, elder races who remember a better age. The frontiers are **Conan-grim** — barbarian clans, decadent sorcerer-cities, pirate coasts, and a serpent-haunted south where the old dark things never died. There is **no single doom** marching on the world. There are a dozen cold rivalries, any one of which could become the next war, and one slowly-healing wound at the center that everyone pretends not to look at.

2. The Powers — Gods, Faiths, and the Old Things

The peoples of the Known World worship a broad pantheon. Few realms revere all of them; most elevate a few and ignore the rest, and a couple deny the pantheon entirely.

- **The Dawnmother** — life, light, harvest, healing. The gentle, most widespread faith of the heartland; her lay-sisters keep waystations and shrines. The default "good cleric" deity.
- **The Forgefather, the One True Flame** — fire, craft, law, the hearth. In most lands one god among many. In **Karth** he is proclaimed the *only* god, and all others named lies — the root of the Iron Covenant's crusading zeal.
- **The Silent Lady, Keeper of the Last Door** — death (the *clean* kind), peace, fate, mercy for the dying. Her priests bury the dead and hunt the undead who refuse her door.
- **The Stormfather / He of the Tides** — sea, storm, weather, oaths sworn on salt water. Worshipped by sailors everywhere and supreme among the **Tidereach** storm-priests.
- **The Ledger (the Coinlord)** — trade, luck, contracts, cities. Patron of **Valmoria** and the **Lumenar League**; a god who keeps accounts and expects to be paid.

- **The Sky-Father and the Ancestor-Host** — the open heaven and the riding dead, revered by the **Khalassar** nomads, who believe their forebears ride beside them into battle.
- **The Twins** — paired gods of war: one of disciplined battle and honest victory, one of slaughter and the red hour. Soldiers pray to the first; berserkers and reavers to the second.
- **The Veiled One** — knowledge, secrets, and arcane magic. Once honored in the Imperium; now a *suspect* faith, blamed by many for the Sundering. Wizards keep their devotions quiet.
- **The Green** — not a god but the **Old Power** of the **Eldwood**: the will of the primeval forest and the fey. Older than the Imperium, older than the pantheon. It keeps its own law and is no one's ally.
- **The Beast-Gods of Ymmu** — savage totem-powers of the southern jungle, hungry and close. They grant real power and take real blood.
- **The Serpent** — the great dark. Worshipped openly only in **Qoph**, the deathless god of dominion, undeath, and the world-before-the-gods. To the northern faiths, "the Serpent" simply *means* evil.

The **dwarves** of Vaultholme revere the **Stone-Ancestors** and the Maker beneath all forges; the **elves** of Yselmark keep faith with the **Evenstar** and the memory of the age before the breaking. Both regard the human pantheon as young.

3. The Deep Past and the Sundering

Before the Imperium there were the elder peoples — the elves of the silver woods, the dwarves under the peaks, the fey of the Eldwood — and, in the far south, the **Serpent** and its kingdoms, which were old when the elves were young. The elves warred with the Serpent across ages now half-forgotten and drove it south, and there it has brooded ever since.

The Aurelian Imperium rose among humankind some nine centuries ago and grew to span the heartland and far beyond — roads, law, aqueducts, legions, and a high tradition of magic unmatched before or since. At its height it was ruled from the great capital of **Aurelis** by an emperor who was also archmage, and it counted the elder races as subjects or rivals to be managed. The elves warned that the Imperium's mages reached too greedily into powers not meant to be held. The Imperium did not listen.

The Sundering came in the year now reckoned as **0**. The accounts disagree on exactly what the imperial magi attempted — to bind a god, to open a permanent gate, to make the emperor deathless, to do all three at once — but they agree on the result. In a single night Aurelis was unmade. A wound was torn in the world at the empire's heart; magic itself was injured, so that in places it runs **wild and unbound**; and the veil between the world and the outer dark was **thinned**, letting things slip through that had no business here. The legions died, the provinces were cut off, and within a generation the Imperium was a memory and a ruin.

The two centuries since have been spent picking up the pieces. The successor kingdoms — **Aurenne** chief among them — each claim the dead empire's mantle. New powers rose where the old order failed: merchant republics, mercenary states, barbarian confederations, the renewed cults of the south. And at the center, the **Sundering Scar** still festers — a blasted ruin-country of wild magic and crawling horrors, too rich in imperial gold to abandon and too deadly to hold.

4. The Present Age — 211 AS

No single shadow threatens the world today. The danger is that *any* of its cold rivalries could catch fire:

- **Aurenne vs. Valmoria** — the two great heartland powers, one claiming the empire by blood and chivalry, the other buying it by gold and charter. Their cold war is fought with loans, marriages, and proxy companies, not yet with armies.
- **The Iron Covenant's crusades** — Karth's militant church pushes outward "by conversion," burning witches and warring on the old faiths and the free clans of the Frostmark.
- **The Khalassar's restlessness** — the steppe khans are quarreling, and a strong Great Khan could unite them; the last time that happened, the east burned.
- **The slow drowning of the Tidereach** and the **creeping wild magic of the Scar's edge**, which poisons the marches that border it — like **Halvedd**, where play begins.
- **The Serpent's patience** — Qoph schemes as it always has, in centuries rather than years. Most of the north thinks the south's evil is a story. It is not.

The state of **magic** colors everything. Arcane power works, but the educated fear it and the common folk distrust it, and near the Scar it cannot be trusted at all. Clerics and the temple faiths are respected; wizards are tolerated, watched, and in Karth, killed.

This is a **sandbox**. There is gold in old ruins, work for swords on every border, and a hundred local troubles a band of capable people could turn to their profit or their ruin. A nobody can become a name out here — which is exactly why the home region is where it is.

5. The Twenty Realms

Grouped by region. Coordinates and exact territory live in the map data; this is the who and the why.

The North — cold, free, and zealous

The Frostmark (*Hjoldar clans*) — A cold land of fjords, tundra, and pine, held by free human clans of hunters, reavers, and skalds. No king rules them; honor, oath, and feud do. They prize freedom above safety and despise the southern empires that once tried to tax their snow — and they distrust sorcery nearly as much as they distrust crowns. *Conan's Cimmeria, with longhouses.*

The Iron Covenant of Karth (*Karthish*) — A stern crusader-theocracy that worships the Forgefather as the One True Flame and names all other gods lies. Orderly, literate, disciplined, and certain of its own righteousness, it expands "by conversion" and outlaws arcane magic on pain of fire. Its cathedral-fortress capital, **Karth-on-the-Flame**, keeps an Eternal Pyre that has not gone out in two hundred years. Admirable and terrible in equal measure.

Vaultholme (*Dwarves of the Deepholds*) — Ancient dwarven hold-cities under the northern peaks, ruled by guild-kings and the Stone Moot. Masters of forge, ledger, and grudge; mercantile but deeply isolationist. Their Iron Gate has not opened to outsiders in eighty years. They are still mining toward doors their ancestors **sealed** before the Sundering — and one of those doors, far out on the frontier, has begun to be knocked upon from the other side.

The East — horse, memory, and silver woods

The Khalassar (*steppe nomads — humans, half-orcs*) — A vast confederation of horse-clans on the eastern Sea of Grass, bound loosely under quarreling khans. Raiders and traders both, devout to the Sky-Father and the riding dead of the Ancestor-Host. Their capital is wherever the Great Khan's tent stands. When one Khan unites the rest, the settled west learns again to fear a horizon full of dust.

Yselmark (*High elves of the East*) — A fading, reclusive elven realm of silver woods and slow-drowning towers, ruled from the **Evenstar Court** at Yssimar. The elves remember the world before the Sundering — they *warned* against it — and they have never forgiven the human Imperium nor trusted the crowns that claim its inheritance. They keep lore the Imperium tried to burn, and lend it rarely and at a price.

The Heartland — the empire's broken inheritance

Aurenne (*Aurennois — humans, half-elves*) — The largest and proudest successor kingdom, chivalric and glorious on the surface, claiming the dead Imperium's crown by right of blood. Beneath the pageantry it is hollowing out: an aging King Aldric IV, feuding dukes, and a treasury that cannot pay for the glory it performs. The closest thing the world has to "the good old kingdom," and rotting gently at the root. *Tolkien's Gondor in genteel decline.*

Valmoria (*Valmorian*) — Aurenne's pragmatic rival: a realm of banks, charters, and a senate of merchant-princes. It buys with gold what Aurenne claims by blood, quietly funds half the continent's wars, and considers Aurenne's chivalry an expensive affectation. Its capital's **Senate Vaults** are reputed undelvable — which is, of course, an invitation.

The Sundering Scar (*no nation*) — The blasted heart of the cataclysm: the drowned-then-ashen ruin of imperial **Aurelis**, a country of wild magic, fused glass, and things that crawled in through the thinned veil. There is no government and no safety, only the richest ruins in the world and the quickest deaths. Its edge poisons every march that borders it.

The Pallid Cities (*the Ash-Dukes*) — Jewel-bright human city-states raised in the Imperium's outer ruins, ruled by masked tyrant-dukes. Pleasure, poison, masque, and quiet forbidden sorcery; beautiful, cruel, and decadently certain the world is ending slowly and best enjoyed while it does. *Pure Conan: the gleaming, rotten city.*

The March of Coin (*the Free Companies*) — Not quite a country: a buffer region run by the **Captains' Compact**, the chartered mercenary companies who rent themselves to every realm in turn. The one place on the continent where a sellsword of *any* blood — human, orc, elf, or stranger — is judged only by their record. Sells war wholesale and peace at a premium.

Halvedd (*the Marchfolk — humans, dwarves, halflings*) — **The home region.** A frontier march where Aurenne, Valmoria, the Free Companies, and the Scar's poisoned edge all collide. Petty lords, free towns, ruin-delvers,

refugees, and opportunity. Detailed in §6.

The Bonelands (*broken khanates, warlords*) — A wind-scoured march east of the Scar, where the Khalassar's old conquests shattered into feuding petty-kingdoms now fought over by warlords and mercenary captains. Every hill is somebody's barrow, and since the Sundering, some of the dead object to being walked on.

The Gloamhold (*drow, duergar, and deeper things*) — Not a surface realm at all but the **Underrealm** below the southeastern hills, whose sinkholes and cave-mouths are its doors. A downward kingdom of warring drow houses, duergar forges, and aberrant horrors that the Sundering stirred from a long sleep. The widest gate, the **Maw of Gloam**, swallows expeditions whole.

The West — coast, coin, and red sails

The Lumenar League (*Lumenese — humans, gnomes*) — A league of west-coast harbor-cities: galleys, ledgers, spies, and the continent's loudest argument over slavery. Rich, scheming, perpetually one bad season from civil war among its own member-cities, and the chief commercial rival of inland Valmoria.

The Scarlet Isles (*corsairs — all bloods*) — A scatter of free ports and pirate-captaincies in the Western Sea, flying no flag but the red one. Polyglot, lawless, and gloriously dangerous, the Isles are where the League's lost cargo, the realms' exiles, and anyone with more nerve than law all wash up. *Conan's Barachan pirates.*

The Tidereach of Seywn (*Seywn folk, sea-elves*) — A half-drowned southwestern coast of fishing-clans and storm-shrines, ruled by a moot of storm-priests of the Stormfather. The land has been sinking slowly since the Sundering tilted the tides; sea-elves and stranger things now share its shallows, and whole villages keep to stilts and boats.

The South — sand, jungle, and the old dark

The Caliphates of Sahl (*Sahli*) — Brass-domed desert cities of caravans, astronomers, poets, and djinn-bargains, divided among rival sultanates who each name the others heretics. Wealthy and learned — the south's keepers of much knowledge the north has lost — and riven by intrigue as intricate as their tilework. *Conan's Shem and the Arabian tradition.*

Qoph, the Serpent Dominion (*Qophic — humans, yuan-ti*) — The oldest and darkest power: a serpent-haunted theocracy of necromancers ruled by a deathless god-king priesthood that has "reigned" through nine recorded deaths. To the northern faiths, *Qoph* is simply the word for the old evil. It schemes in centuries, and it is patient. *Conan's Stygia — the serpent at the world's root.*

Ymmu, the Sunscorch (*Ymmu tribes*) — A vast southern jungle-and-savanna of tribal kingdoms, ivory, fever, and beast-god cults whose gods are close and hungry. Slavers from Sahl and the Isles raid its coasts; its interior has swallowed every army ever sent to chart it and given none of them back.

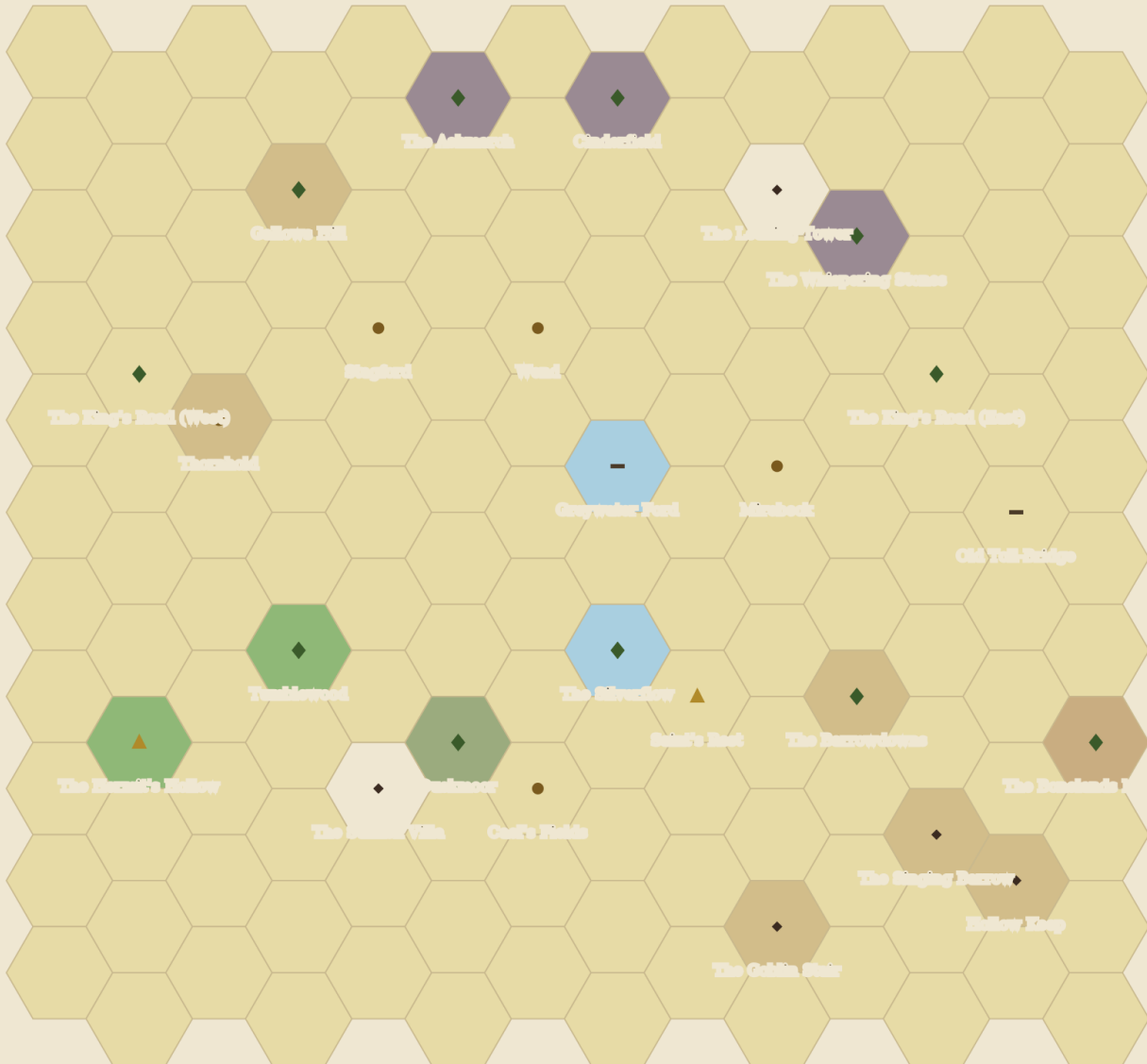
The Elder Wild

The Eldwood (Sylvarine) (*wood elves and fey*) — The great primeval forest of the southwest, where the world's first trees still stand and the fey keep their own ancient law under the **Greenmoot**. It has no central ruler and wants none. Neutral, patient, and older than the Imperium and its gods alike — it outlasted the empire, and it fully

intends to outlast everyone now arguing over the empire's bones.

6. The Home Region — The March of Halvedd

The March of Halvedd



The March of Halvedd — the party's home ground.

Play begins in **Halvedd**, the frontier march detailed at fine resolution in `home_halvedd.py` and rendered in `halvedd_home_region.svg`. It sits in the gap between Aurenne (west), Valmoria (east), the Free Companies (southwest), and — along its **northern edge** — the poisoned **Ashmarch** where the Sundering Scar begins. The

King's Road runs east–west through it; the river **Silverflow** cuts down through its middle toward the south.

It is governed in name by **Baron Cael Thorn** from the small border-keep of **Thornhold**, a lord deeper in debt to Valmoria than he can ever repay. In practice it governs itself, town by town. The hub is **Wend**, a walled caravan-town with a market, the **Broken Wheel** inn, a Free-Company chapter-house, and an overworked reeve named **Maddox**.

Key locales (all carried as hex data, with descriptions and flags):

- **The Leaning Tower** — a half-collapsed pre-Sundering mage-tower on the Ashmarch; warded lower vaults, unlooted. A textbook first delve.
- **The Singing Barrow** — the greatest of the Barrowdowns' tombs, cracked open last winter; cold air and a faint keening come out, and nothing has come back.
- **The Sunken Villa** — an imperial villa swallowed by the Duskmoor fen, its tiled halls now below the waterline and far from empty.
- **The Goblin Stair** — a warren of Boneland-refugee goblins now raiding the Valmoria road.
- **Hollow Keep** — an abandoned Free-Company strongpoint the Compact will pay to see reclaimed.
- **Cinderfield & the Whispering Stones** — the Ashmarch's haunted edge, where the wild magic of the Scar leaks south and imperial boundary-stones murmur in a dead tongue.
- Plus the safe harbors — **Saint's Rest** shrine, the **Hermit's Hollow** — and the working country between: Stagford, Mirebeck, Greywater Ford, Cael's Fields, the Old Toll-Bridge, Tumblewood, and Duskmoor.

Halvedd is built to do what a home region should: a safe town to return to, three or four starter dungeons within a day's ride, a sympathetic patron and a shady one, and the whole rest of the continent reachable down the King's Road when the party is ready.

7. How This Stays True — Working With the Engine

Everything in this bible is enforced by data, not trusted to recall:

- **The map is data.** Every hex on both the continent map and the Halvedd map carries data-hex (its coordinate), data-terrain, data-contents (its locale), and data-neighbors (its explicit adjacent hexes). Movement and adjacency are read from data-neighbors — never eyeballed from the picture. The neighbor lists are computed geometrically from the engine's own hex math, so they always match what the engine believes.
- **The map is generated.** `python tools/build_world.py` rebuilds both SVGs from `known_world.py` + `home_halvedd.py` and runs a validator: every realm must have territory, every locale must sit on a real in-grid hex, and every neighbor reference must resolve. Edit the data, regenerate, and the picture can never drift from the truth.
- **Locales seed the database.** `known_world.seed_campaign(repo, cid)` writes the named locales into the campaign DB as real, queried game state.

- **The story is locked canon.** Villains, secrets, and clocks (when authored) live in canon .json via the engine's canon tools, to be read and run to — never improvised over.
- **Gaps get flagged, not filled.** Where this document or the data is silent, that silence is reported, not papered over with invention.

Next steps when you're ready: lock a starting storyline into canon (villain, goal, twist, win-condition, clock, sealed secret), and build out the first dungeon — the Leaning Tower — as a room graph with data-exits, the same way the overworld is a hex graph.